Decision Maker

You wish to	Look out for this in a processor	Look out for this in a motherboard	Products suited to your task	Our platform of choice
Play games, watch DVD movies, burn MP3 CDs, encode video files	A processor with more than or equal to 256 KB of L2 cache, high core speed, higher memory bandwidth	Support for a high-end processor and memory. More than four PCI slots, more than two memory slots, features such as USB 2.0, Serial ATA and Bluetooth	Intel Pentium 4 2.0 GHz to 3.06 GHz on an MSI 845E MAX2 or a Gigabyte GA-8GE667-PRO board. AMD XP 1800+ to AMD XP 2800+ on an MSI KT4 Ultra or a DFI AD77-infinity motherboard	Intel Pentium P4 3.06 GHz processor on the MSI 845GE MAX2 motherboard Price: Rs 50,500
Work with content creation applications such as Adobe Photoshop and Adobe Premeire	A processor that is high on performance and comes reasonably priced	Support for features such as USB 2.0, FireWire, Serial ATA, RAID, Bluetooth, onboard video and onboard sound	Intel Pentium 4 2.08 GHz or a 3.06 GHz on a Krypton P4TDQ or MSI KT4-ULTRA board. Any AMD processor on an MSI KT4 Ultra or an ASUS A7S266 motherboard	AMD XP 1800+ on an MSI KT4 Ultra motherboard Price: Rs 10,180
Work with office applications such as Microsoft Word and browse the Internet	A processor that has enough power and is light on your pocket	Support for features such as onboard video and onboard sound, along with USB 2.0.	An AMD XP 1700+, 1800+ and 2000+ processor on an ASUS A7S266 or a Mercury KT266A-FDSX motherboard	AMD XP 1800+ on an ASUS A7S266 motherboard Price Rs 8,240

Your Smart Buying Checklist

BUYING TIPS

Buying motherboards

■ A motherboard may present itself in various versions. The MSI 845 MAX2, for example, is available as Pure, FIR and FISR, where the Pure is the base model and the others have certain feature additions such as RAID, USB 2.0, etc but for minimal increments in price.

■ If you are a hardcore gamer or prefer over-clocking, then check that the space around the CPU is quite spacious so that you can install a larger heatsink-fan combo to keep it cool.

■ While buying a motherboard, ensure that its chipset supports both the speed of your processor and the speed of the Front Side Bus (FSB).

■ With your application area in mind, ensure that your motherboard is sufficiently feature rich. In particular, make sure that it has enough PCI slots and memory slots for future expansion.

■ If cost is not a hindrance, opt for a motherboard that has both an onboard video chipset and an AGP slot. This will give you greater flexibility while making a future upgrade.

■ Ensure that your motherboard has an onboard sound chipset and if you so require, integrated Ethernet.

■ While buying a motherboard, check whether the board supports the type of memory that your system has: buyers of DDR SDRAM should be especially careful in this regard.

Buying processors

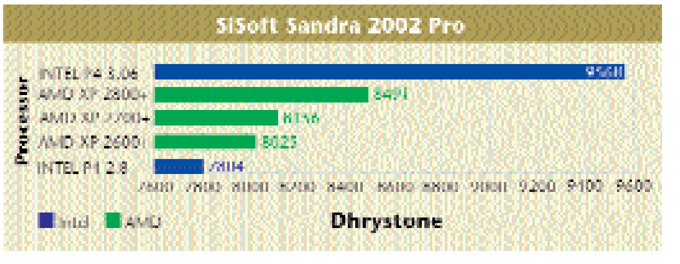
■ Present generation CPUs are power hungry; ensure that you have an SMPSrated at least at 250 W, preferably 350 W.

■ Whether you buy from Intel or AMD, make sure that you are buying genuine. This can be confirmed by the hologram seal on the Intel CPU box. For AMD, make sure that the plastic casing is not broken.

■ If you plan on CPU-intensive tasks such as graphics processing, animation and gaming, opt for one that has 256 KB or more L2 cache. The Pentium 4 Northwood has 512 KB of L2 cache, for example.

■ The new AMD processors sporting the Thoroughbred codename require less core voltage and have low power dissipation and this makes them expensive. Hence, if power requirement and heat dissipation is not an issue, you can opt for the Palomino core which is much cheaper.

■ Invest in a good heatsink-fan combo for your processor, even if you do not plan on overclocking your system.



just that. The board features onboard video, sound, USB 2.0 and Ethernet and these add to the overall appeal of the board. The Athlon XP 1700+ makes a great combination with this board, because of its pricing. As mentioned earlier, an extremely fast processor would be overkill, which is why the XP 1700+ is our choice for the best solution.

What it all leads to

From our test analysis and scoring, one facet of the AMD v/s Intel war comes across clearly: although AMD processors are great performers and on the whole, affordably priced, they are let down by their motherboards, more specifically their chipsets. This becomes all the more apparent in the Content Creation application area where AMD processors bagged nine of the 10 top spots but their motherboard counterparts only managed to gain two positions within the same category. The SiS 740 chipset came out as the best AMD supporter, followed at some distance by the VIA KT266A and the VIA KM266 here. As far as performance chipset goes, nothing touches the VIA KT400 that beats within the feature-rich heart of the MSI KT4-Ultra.

On the other side of the fence the picture was truly reversed: while good performers, Intel processors cost an arm, a leg and then some. The motherboards available for these processors are varied, numerous and it is not too hard to find one that performs well and is low-priced—such as the SiS 650GL-based Mercury KOB845G. Cost no factor, nothing can beat an Intel-based solution for stability and performance under mission-critical applications or games. The Athlon XP range of processors offer great value for all application areas, especially the office user who needs decent performance at a reasonable price.